



AIR SPECTACLE AT HENDON

The popular obsession with aviation peaked in 1911 with a large number of record-breaking flights. The English public's enthusiasm was catered for at the regular flying meetings held at Hendon, near London, between 1911 and 1939.

and Dublin. Although with less intensity, the craze also gripped the United States, with important meetings at Los Angeles, Boston, and Belmont Park on Long Island, New York.

The Belmont Park meet, held in October 1910, did most to promote the cause of aviation in the United States. It was attended by prominent American businessmen, political leaders, and military top brass, and its main contests – salted with controversy – excited much popular interest. The race for the Gordon Bennett trophy, first contested at Reims and now an annual event, brought spills that filled the newspaper headlines. The field of international contestants was required to fly 20 times around a 3-mile (5-km) circuit. Only two made the distance, as a series of often spectacular crashes left three pilots in the hospital. Englishman Claude Grahame-White, flying a Blériot monoplane with a 100hp Gnome rotary engine,

CAL RODGERS AND THE VIN FIZ

IN SEPTEMBER 1911, former college football star, Calbraith Perry Rodgers set out to win the \$50,000 prize, put up by the flamboyant publisher William Randolph Hearst, for the first coast-to-coast flight across the United States in under 30 days. Rodgers raised financing from the Armour Company of Chicago, which used the pilot's Wright EX as an advertising board for its carbonated drink Vin Fiz.

Amid a blaze of publicity, Rodgers took off from Sheepshead Bay, Brooklyn, on September 17, bound for Long Beach, California. He crashed the following day, and from then on his progress across the United States – tracked by a special train carrying, among others, his wife, his mother, and the Wright brothers' mechanic Charles Taylor – was a catalog of mishaps and error. By the time he reached Chicago, he had already encountered so many delays that he had no hope left of winning the prize money. But Rodgers was not a quitter. He told a reporter: "I am bound for Los Angeles and the Pacific Ocean... and if canvas, steel, and wire, together with a little brawn, tendon, and brain, stick with me, I mean to get there."



CALAMITY CAL

Cal Rodgers poses, grinning, cigar in mouth, sitting in his Wright EX "Vin Fiz" biplane with a top speed of 55mph (88kph). An established automobile and speedboat racer, he was an accident-prone flier (below), crashing 19 times during the trip and badly injuring himself.



COAST TO COAST

This map shows the route of the Vin Fiz during its trouble-plagued transcontinental flight. Rodgers made 69 stops along the way, finishing 84 days after he began, having spent more than 82 hours in the air.

It took Rodgers 49 days to reach California, by which time he had survived 18 crashes. Then, still 9 miles (14km) short of Long Beach, he crashed again, breaking both legs and a collarbone. Hospitalized, he declared his determination to "finish that flight" – and he did, eventually reaching the Pacific 84 days after leaving New York. Only two wingstruts and a rudder remained from his original airplane. Rodgers died the following year, when a seagull became jammed in his aircraft's rudder during an exhibition flight at Long Beach in April 1912. Unable to control his plane, Rodgers crashed into the ocean.

